



Figure 1: Using Cloud editor /jsbin.com

The Jade philosophy

Jade shares the same philosophy as HAML:

- Markup should be beautiful
- Markup should be DRY (Don't Repeat Yourself)
- Markup should be well indented
- The HTML structure should be clear

Snippet 1 gives an example of a basic HTML page with the title, heading and paragraph.

Jade	HTML
doctype html	<!DOCTYPE html>
html	<html>
title Hello, Jade	<head>
body	<title>Hello, Jade</title>
h1 This is a heading	</head>
p This is a para-	<body>
graph.	This is a Heading
	This is a paragraph.
	</body>
	</html>

Snippet 1: Your first 'Hello, Jade' program

This example is so clear that you might be tempted to skip the remainder of this article. Don't! There is even more power in Jade!

Why learn Jade?

There are many reasons to learn Jade. It significantly improves the speed at which Web pages are produced. Besides, it also eases the overall maintenance of HTML pages because the code is more readable.

Jade includes programmatic constructs for decisions (if-else) and looping. It also has support for variables and substitution. This is the basic feature of a template language.

There are often one or more sections of HTML pages in a site that get repeated across multiple HTML files. Jade makes sharing easy with sections like headers and footers in one file, and can easily insert them in many pages which share the same content using features like *include* and *inheritance*.

Jade is whitespace sensitive language, which means that indentation, which is done for better readability, defines a block. For instance, in the code shown in Snippet 1, h1

(heading) and p (paragraph) are indented. This tells Jade that it is a new block and defines the boundary of the body (<body>).

In a literal sense, the overall keystrokes required to code a page of HTML are reduced in Jade. Typing of '<' and '>' for opening tags and closing tags is not required. This also eliminates the possibility of errors caused by the wrong placement of matching tags.

Jade is the default template engine in the Node Express framework. It is written in and generates JavaScript output, which goes well with the trend of 'JavaScript everywhere'.

Installation and set-up

Using a Cloud editor

The simplest way to try Jade without the hassle of any installation is via a browser, using an online Cloud editor. JSbin is an online IDE for Web programming. Visit <http://jsbin.com> and select 'Jade' in the HTML window (Figure 1).

Setting up Jade on your computer

In the first place, you should have npm (node package manager) already installed on your computer. For installation of Node.js and npm, please refer to the OSFY article, 'Developing Applications Using Node.js' published in the October 2013 issue. To install Jade from the command line, type:

```
$ npm install jade --global
```

To check if the installation is complete, use the following command:

```
$ jade --version
```

The version used at the time of writing this article is 1.9.2.

Getting started

Type Snippet 1 into a file and name it *hello.jade*. Ensure that your editor does not have 'tab to spaces' conversion. Let each indent be a tab. Make sure about this since it is most important.

From the directory where *hello.jade* is located, type the commands below to generate your HTML file:

```
$ jade -P . // dot at end of command is for current directory
$ jade -P hello.jade // convert one file to HTML
```

This will generate a file *hello.html*.

It's important to note that you should not open a *.jade* file in a browser. You should only open the *.html* generated file in a browser to check the output. If you are using an online IDE (like jsbin.com), you can see a live preview.

The very first line of HTML is the doctype. Jade has many shorthand notations that eliminate the need to remember long text or switch between files to copy text. These are listed in Table 1.